

The Berlin Wall

1961 – 1989

Ten real primary and secondary sources, with the evidence quoted from each, what it proves, how reliable it is, and where it came from. Built to be printed, cut out and stuck onto your chart.

Every source below is a genuine, checkable document held in a named archive. Full web addresses are on the last page.

STEP 1

Print it

Print all pages on A4. Use colour if you can — the coloured badges are what let you sort the sources by type on your chart.

STEP 2

Cut along the dashed lines

Every dashed box is designed to be cut out: the ten source cards, the definition boxes and the diagrams.

STEP 3

Add the photos

Each card has a grey slot marked **P1–P8**. Open **photo-sheet.html**, print it, cut out the matching photo and glue it into the slot.

STEP 4

Lay out your chart

Use the master chart on page 9 as your plan. Group the cards by **source type** and run them left-to-right by **year**.

WHAT IS IN THIS PACK

Page 2	Definitions to cut out
Page 8	Diagrams: the border strip & divided Berlin
Page 10	Full source list with web addresses

Page 3–7	The ten source cards
Page 9	Escape figures, timeline & master chart
Separate file	photo-sheet.html — the 8 photographs

About the photographs. The photographs are not printed inside this PDF, because they are held on archive websites and have to be loaded from there. They are all real, and they are all free to reuse for schoolwork. Open the file **photo-sheet.html** in any web browser: the eight photographs load straight from the Wikimedia Commons archive, with the photographer, date and copyright licence printed under each one. Print that page and glue the photos into the slots. If your teacher asks where a photo came from, the answer is printed under it.

The first eight boxes are the words you need to **analyse** a source. The last six are the words you need to **understand the Berlin Wall**. Cut them out and put them down the side of your chart.

Primary source

Evidence created at the time by someone who was there. It has not been filtered through a later writer.

In this pack: S1, S2, S3, S4, S5, S6, S8, S9

Secondary source

Evidence made later by someone studying the event, usually by gathering and checking many primary sources.

In this pack: S7 and S10 — both compiled by historians after 1990.

Provenance

Where a source came from: who made it, when, for whom, and why. You judge a source by its provenance before you judge its content.

Example: S5 was written by the officer whose own men did the shooting — that changes how you read it.

Bias

When a source leans one way because of who made it. Bias does not make a source useless — it makes it useful evidence of what that side wanted people to believe.

Example: S4 is pure propaganda, and that is exactly why it is good evidence.

Reliability

How far you can trust what a source says actually happened. A source can be unreliable about facts but still reliable about attitudes.

Test it: does anything else independently say the same thing?

Corroboration

Checking one source against another. Two sources from opposite sides that agree on a fact make that fact very strong.

Example: S1 and S2 are both East German — and they flatly contradict each other.

Utility

How useful a source is for the specific question you are answering. A source can be biased and still be highly useful.

Ask: useful for *what*? Always name the question.

Propaganda

Information published deliberately to make people support a government or cause, whether or not it is true.

In this pack: S3 and S4 are both official East German propaganda.

GDR / DDR (East Germany)

The German Democratic Republic, 1949–1990. A communist one-party state allied to the Soviet Union. It built the Wall.

Ruled by: the SED — the Socialist Unity Party.

FRG / BRD (West Germany)

The Federal Republic of Germany, the democratic, capitalist state allied to the USA, Britain and France. West Berlin was tied to it.

Key point: West Berlin sat 160 km *inside* East Germany.

Republikflucht

"Flight from the republic" — the East German legal term for leaving without permission. It was a crime.

Scale: about 2.7–3.5 million people left before 1961.

Antifaschistischer Schutzwall

"Anti-fascist protection rampart" — the official East German name for the Wall. It claimed the Wall kept fascists *out*, not citizens *in*.

Reality: ordinary East Germans never used the phrase.

The death strip

The cleared ground behind the outer wall: raked sand, floodlights, dog runs, trip-wire fences, anti-vehicle trenches and watchtowers.

See: the cross-section diagram on page 8.

Checkpoint Charlie

The crossing point on Friedrichstraße used by Allied staff and foreigners. In October 1961 US and Soviet tanks faced each other here.

Nearby: Peter Fechter was shot 200 m away (S5).

S1

PRESS CONFERENCE

15 JUNE 1961

EAST GERMANY

“Nobody intends to put up a wall”

Walter Ulbricht, leader of East Germany, answering a West German journalist at an international press conference in the House of Ministries, East Berlin. Printed in the party newspaper *Neues Deutschland* the next day.

THE EVIDENCE

“Ich verstehe Ihre Frage so, daß es in Westdeutschland Menschen gibt, die wünschen, daß wir die Bauarbeiter der DDR dazu mobilisieren eine Mauer aufzurichten. Mir ist nicht bekannt, daß eine solche Absicht besteht. *Niemand hat die Absicht, eine Mauer zu errichten.*”

“I understand your question to mean that there are people in West Germany who wish that we would mobilise the construction workers of the GDR to put up a wall. I am not aware that any such intention exists. Nobody intends to put up a wall.”

WHAT IT SHOWS

The East German leader publicly denied any plan for a wall **59 days before he built one**. It proves the decision was kept secret — and it is the single most famous lie of the Cold War.

RELIABILITY

Completely reliable as a record of *what was said* — it was public and recorded. Completely unreliable as a statement of fact. Note that Ulbricht was the first to say the word “wall”.

Cite as: Walter Ulbricht, international press conference, East Berlin, 15 June 1961; transcript in *Neues Deutschland*, 16 June 1961. Reproduced by German History in Documents and Images (GHI) and Berlin-Geschichte.

P1

GLUE PHOTO HERE

Conrad Schumann's leap

Border guard Conrad Schumann jumps the barbed wire into West Berlin, 15 August 1961 — two months after this denial. Photo: CIA collection (public domain).

S2

SECRET GOVERNMENT RECORD

1 AUG 1961

USSR & EAST GERMANY

Khrushchev and Ulbricht plan the border closure

Notes of a private conversation between **Nikita Khrushchev** (Soviet leader) and **Walter Ulbricht**, taken twelve days before the Wall went up. Secret at the time; declassified after 1990 and published by the Wilson Center Digital Archive.

THE EVIDENCE

Khrushchev, on East Germany's problem: “*Many engineers have fled the GDR. You should consider — shouldn't we send you perhaps some engineers from the Soviet Union? They won't run away. [...] But something must be done.*”

Ulbricht presses for economic help from the other communist states in case the West retaliates once the border is shut.

WHAT IT SHOWS

Behind closed doors the real reason was **economic collapse through emigration** — skilled workers leaving — not fascism or Western attack. It also shows Moscow, not just East Berlin, was in on the decision.

RELIABILITY

Very high. It was never meant to be read by the public, so there was no reason to spin it. This is the source that flatly contradicts S1, S3 and S4.

Cite as: “Notes on the Conversation of Comrade N. S. Khrushchev with Comrade W. Ulbricht on 1 August 1961”, Wilson Center Digital Archive, International History Declassified.

P2

GLUE PHOTO HERE

Building the Wall

East German workers under armed guard building the barrier, Berlin, August 1961. Photo: CIA collection (public domain).

S3

NEWSPAPER ARTICLE

14 AUG 1961

EAST GERMANY

“Measures to protect peace” — the front page

Front page of *Neues Deutschland*, the official daily newspaper of the SED (the East German ruling party), published the morning after the border was sealed. This is a state-controlled newspaper, not a free press.

THE EVIDENCE

“Zur Unterbindung der feindlichen Tätigkeit der revanchistischen und militaristischen Kräfte Westdeutschlands und Westberlins wird eine solche Kontrolle an den Grenzen der Deutschen Demokratischen Republik ... eingeführt, wie sie an den Grenzen jedes souveränen Staates üblich ist.”

“To stop the hostile activity of the revanchist and militarist forces of West Germany and West Berlin, controls are being introduced at the borders of the German Democratic Republic ... such as are normal at the borders of any sovereign state.”

WHAT IT SHOWS

The official public justification: the Wall was **defensive** and **normal**. The paper also claims most Berliners approved — useful evidence of how the state managed the news.

RELIABILITY

Low as fact — every East German newspaper was censored by the party. High as evidence of the **official line**. Compare it directly with S2, written thirteen days earlier in private.

Cite as: “Maßnahmen zum Schutz des Friedens und zur Sicherung der Deutschen Demokratischen Republik in Kraft”, *Neues Deutschland*, 14 August 1961, p. 1. Reproduced by GHDI; full run at ND-Archiv.

P3

GLUE PHOTO HERE

Reading the news
People in Leipzig read an *Extrablatt* (special edition) about the building of the Wall, August 1961. Photo: German Federal Archive (Bundesarchiv), CC BY-SA.

S4

PROPAGANDA PAMPHLET

1961

EAST GERMANY

“In praise of the Berlin Wall”

A 48-page illustrated pamphlet issued by the **SED** within weeks of 13 August 1961, produced by the “Fighting Group Berlin-Mitte” and Berlin publishing houses. Handed out to workers and party members.

THE EVIDENCE

“On 13 August 1961 peace-loving Berliners won a battle for peace. The battle groups of Berlin's working class ... put an end to subversive activity against the GDR by spies, slave-traders, and Revanchist organizations based in West Berlin.”

The back cover reads: “West German militarism has been frustrated by the building of the Berlin Wall.”

WHAT IT SHOWS

How the state sold the Wall to its own people: as a **victory**, not a restriction. The language — “spies”, “slave-traders” — shows the enemy being invented to justify the barrier.

RELIABILITY

Worthless as a factual account. Excellent as evidence of **propaganda technique**. Notice it never mentions the 2.7 million people who had already left (see S7).

Cite as: SED pamphlet, 1961, translated as “In Praise of the Berlin Wall”, German Propaganda Archive, Calvin University (ed. Randall Bytwerk).

P4

GLUE PHOTO HERE

The Wall at the Brandenburg Gate
The barrier sealing off Berlin's most famous landmark, 1961. Photo: German Federal Archive (Bundesarchiv), CC BY-SA.

S5

MILITARY REPORT (SECRET)

17 AUG 1962

EAST GERMANY

The border commander's report on the shooting of Peter Fechter

Internal report by the commander of the **1st Border Brigade** on the day 18-year-old bricklayer **Peter Fechter** was shot climbing the Wall near Checkpoint Charlie. Classified; now held at the German Federal Archive.

THE EVIDENCE

“Die zweite Person wurde beim Anspringen an die Mauer getroffen ... *die Person brach daraufhin an der Mauer zusammen und schrie um Hilfe.*” — Later: a smoke screen was laid from the windows of the ruin at Zimmerstraße 72–74, under cover of which the wounded man was recovered.

“The second person was hit as he jumped up at the Wall ... the person then collapsed at the Wall and screamed for help.” Four guards fired 35 shots. Fechter bled to death over roughly an hour while both sides refused to cross. He was declared dead at 17:00.

WHAT IT SHOWS

The shoot-to-kill order in practice, described by the army itself. The report's conclusions are about **plugging the gap** and bricking up windows — not about the death of a teenager.

RELIABILITY

Written by the side that did the shooting, to protect itself — it claims warning shots were fired, which the later trial disputed. But it is a secret internal document, so the basic facts are strong.

Cite as: “Bericht des Kommandeurs der 1. Grenzbrigade über den Fluchtversuch und die Erschießung von Peter Fechter”, 17 August 1962. BArch, VA-07/16930, Bl. 2–5. Via Chronik der Mauer.



Armed border guards
East German border troops on duty at the Wall. Photo: CIA collection (public domain). *The photograph of Fechter himself is under copyright — see the source list.*

S6

POLITICAL SPEECH

26 JUNE 1963

USA / WEST

Kennedy: “Ich bin ein Berliner”

Speech by US President **John F. Kennedy** to a crowd of several hundred thousand at the Rudolph Wilde Platz, West Berlin. Filmed, broadcast and transcribed; the record is held by the US National Archives.

THE EVIDENCE

“Freedom has many difficulties and democracy is not perfect, but *we have never had to put a wall up to keep our people in*, to prevent them from leaving us. ... While the wall is the most obvious and vivid demonstration of the failures of the Communist system, for all the world to see, we take no satisfaction in it, for it is ... *an offense not only against history but an offense against humanity.*”

WHAT IT SHOWS

The Western argument in one line: a state that has to **lock its people in** has already lost the argument. It also shows the Wall being used as a propaganda weapon by *both* sides.

RELIABILITY

Reliable as a record of what was said. But it is a political speech to a friendly crowd — designed to reassure West Berliners, not to analyse. Kennedy **did not act to remove the Wall**.

Cite as: John F. Kennedy, Remarks at the Rudolph Wilde Platz, Berlin, 26 June 1963. US National Archives; transcript via the Miller Center and the JFK Presidential Library.



A family divided
West Berliners hold children up so relatives on the eastern side can see them over the Wall. Photo: CIA collection (public domain).

S7

STATISTICS

1949–1990

SECONDARY / RESEARCH

Migration figures: East to West Germany

Official migration statistics compiled from **West German and East German government records**, published as a data table by German History in Documents and Images (GHDl), a project of the German Historical Institute.

THE EVIDENCE

People moving to West Germany, by year:
1953: 331,390 · **1960:** 199,188 · **1961:** 207,026
1962: 21,365 · **1963:** 42,622 · **1988:** 39,832 · **1989:** 343,854

Around 2.7 million people left between 1949 and August 1961. After the Wall went up, the number fell by roughly 90% in a single year.

WHAT IT SHOWS

Hard proof that **the Wall worked**, and proof of *why* it was built. The 1989 spike shows the system failing again the moment the border reopened.

RELIABILITY

High — two governments counted independently and the totals broadly agree. But numbers alone hide the human reason people left; pair this with S5 and S10.

Cite as: "East-West German Immigration Statistics (1949–1990)" and "Refugee Movement (1950–1963)", German History in Documents and Images, German Historical Institute.

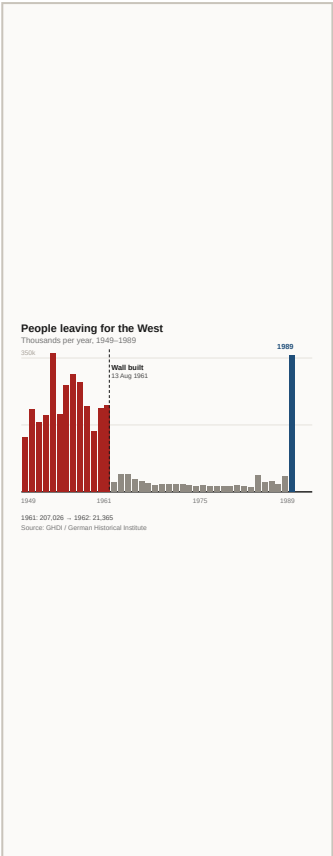


Chart drawn from the figures in S7. You can cut this out and use it as your graph.

S8

POLITICAL SPEECH

12 JUNE 1987

USA / WEST

Reagan: “Mr. Gorbachev, tear down this wall!”

Speech by US President **Ronald Reagan** at the Brandenburg Gate, West Berlin, delivered behind bulletproof glass and amplified so it could be heard on the eastern side. Official text held by the Reagan Presidential Library.

THE EVIDENCE

“General Secretary Gorbachev, if you seek peace, if you seek prosperity for the Soviet Union and Eastern Europe, if you seek liberalization: Come here to this gate! Mr. Gorbachev, open this gate! *Mr. Gorbachev, tear down this wall!*”

Earlier in the same speech: “Every man is a Berliner, forced to look upon a scar.”

WHAT IT SHOWS

The Wall still standing 26 years on, and the West using it as a public challenge. Reagan’s own State Department tried to cut the line — evidence of a **split in Western policy**.

RELIABILITY

Reliable text, but treat the popular claim that this speech *caused* the Wall to fall with caution. The Wall fell 29 months later for reasons largely inside the Eastern bloc (see S9).

Cite as: Ronald Reagan, “Remarks on East-West Relations at the Brandenburg Gate in West Berlin”, 12 June 1987. Ronald Reagan Presidential Library & US National Archives.



Checkpoint Charlie from the air
The crossing point on Friedrichstraße where US and Soviet tanks faced off in October 1961. Photo: CIA collection (public domain).

S9

GOVERNMENT DECREE

9 NOV 1989

EAST GERMANY

“Schabowski's note” — the order that opened the Wall

The draft decision of the **GDR Council of Ministers** on travel and permanent exit, circulated on 9 November 1989. Marked *Vertrauliche Verschlusssache* (confidential). These were the notes Günter Schabowski read out, unprepared, at a live press conference that evening.

THE EVIDENCE

“Privatreisen nach dem Ausland können ohne Vorliegen von Voraussetzungen (Reiseanlässe und Verwandtschaftsverhältnisse) beantragt werden. ... Ständige Ausreisen können über alle Grenzübergangsstellen der DDR zur BRD bzw. zu Berlin (West) erfolgen.”

“Private trips abroad may be applied for without preconditions (reasons for travel or family relationships) ... Permanent exit may take place via all GDR border crossings to the FRG or to Berlin (West).” The document says the press release was to be published **the next day**, 10 November.

WHAT IT SHOWS

The Wall opened partly **by accident**. The decree was meant to control emigration, not end it — and to start a day later. Asked when it applied, Schabowski said immediately, and crowds went to the crossings.

RELIABILITY

An official internal document — very reliable for what was *decided*. It cannot tell you what Schabowski actually said on air; for that you need the press conference recording.

Cite as: “Zeitweilige Übergangsregelung für Reisen und ständige Ausreise aus der DDR”, 9 November 1989. BStU, MfS, Arbeitsbereich Neiber Nr. 553, Bl. 15–19. Via Chronik der Mauer.



Anti-tank defences
Concrete and steel obstacles inside the border strip. Photo: CIA collection (public domain).

S10

RESEARCH DATABASE

Published 2017–19

SECONDARY / ACADEMIC

Victims at the Wall: the official death toll

A joint research project by the **Berlin Wall Foundation** and the **Centre for Contemporary History (ZZF) Potsdam**, funded by the German federal government. Researchers went through border-troop and Stasi files, 1990s trial records, and interviewed families.

THE EVIDENCE

“Between 1961 and 1989, *at least 140 people were killed at the Berlin Wall* or died under circumstances directly connected with the GDR border regime. In addition, at least 251 people from East and West died before, during or after controls at Berlin border crossings while travelling.”

Altogether 576 cases were recorded and checked. Earlier counts had ranged from 78 to over 200, depending on the criteria used — this project set a clear definition and tested every case.

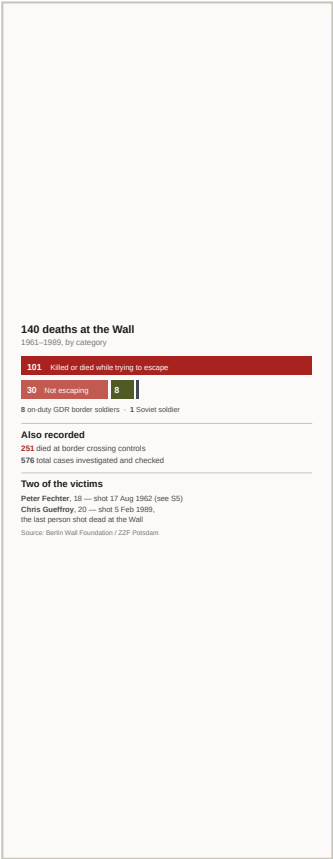
WHAT IT SHOWS

The human cost, established by evidence rather than by either side's propaganda. It also shows **how history gets settled**: by defining terms and checking records.

RELIABILITY

The most reliable source in this pack. But note it is **secondary** and it says “at least” — it excludes people who died of grief, and figures depend on the definition chosen.

Cite as: Hans-Hermann Hertle & Maria Nooke (eds.), *The Victims at the Berlin Wall, 1961–1989: A Biographical Handbook*, ZZF Potsdam & Berlin Wall Foundation; database at Chronik der Mauer (figures as of 9 August 2017; 3rd rev. edn., Berlin 2019).



Breakdown drawn from the figures in S10.

What “the Wall” actually was

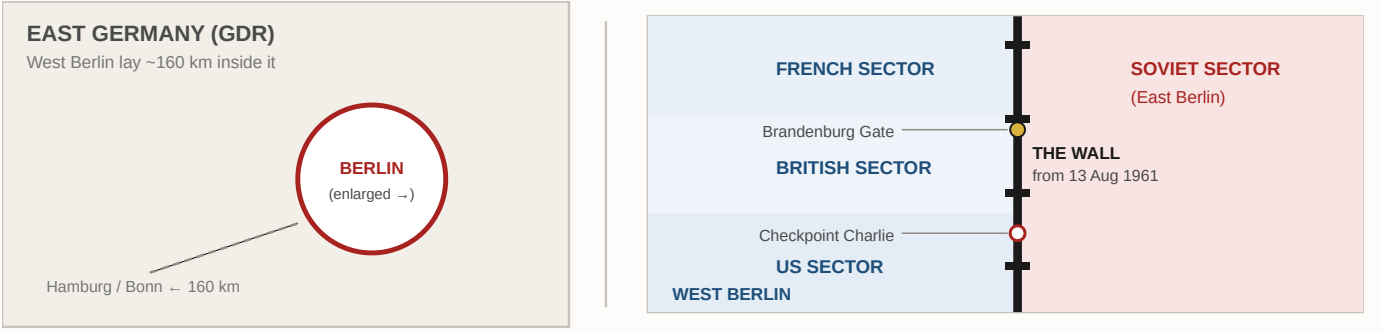
People imagine one wall. It was a system roughly 30–100 m deep, designed so that anyone who got past the first fence could still be seen, tracked and shot before reaching the last one. East is on the left; freedom is on the right.



Source for the measurements: Berlin Wall Foundation (Stiftung Berliner Mauer) border-installation figures, as summarised in the Berlin Wall reference data. Diagram drawn for this project — it is a labelled diagram, not a photograph.

Why West Berlin was the problem

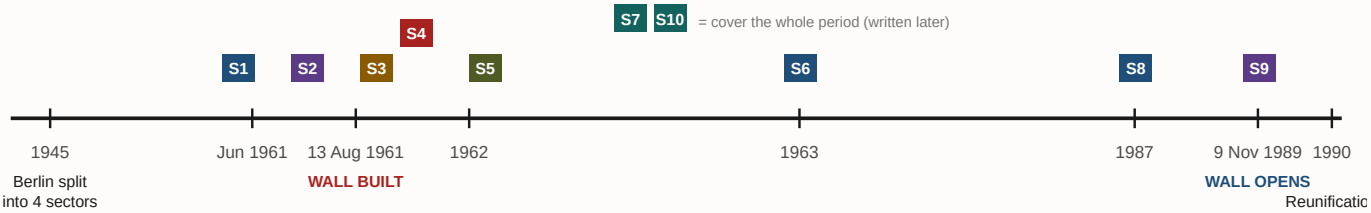
Berlin was split into four occupation sectors in 1945. The three Western sectors became West Berlin — an island of the West sitting about 160 km inside communist East Germany. Until 1961 anyone in East Germany could travel to East Berlin, walk across a street, and be in the West.



Note: a simplified schematic to show the political structure, not an accurate street map. The real Wall ran a winding 43.1 km through the city and then a further 111.9 km around West Berlin's outer edge.

Where each source sits in the story

The numbers show where each of your ten sources falls on the timeline.



THE MASTER CHART — USE THIS AS YOUR LAYOUT PLAN

#	SOURCE TYPE	YEAR	WHOSE SIDE	WHAT IT PROVES	P / S
S1	PRESS CONFERENCE	15 Jun 1961	East Germany	The leader publicly denied a wall was planned — 59 days before building one.	Primary
S2	SECRET RECORD	1 Aug 1961	USSR / GDR	The real motive in private: skilled workers were fleeing and the economy was failing.	Primary
S3	NEWSPAPER	14 Aug 1961	East Germany	The official public story: the Wall was a normal, defensive border control.	Primary
S4	PROPAGANDA	1961	East Germany	How the state sold the Wall to its own people — as a victory over “spies”.	Primary
S5	MILITARY REPORT	17 Aug 1962	East Germany	The shoot-to-kill order in practice: 35 shots, an 18-year-old left to die.	Primary
S6	SPEECH	26 Jun 1963	USA / West	The Western argument: a state that must lock people in has already lost.	Primary
S7	STATISTICS	1949–90	Neutral / research	The Wall worked: emigration fell about 90% in one year, 1961 to 1962.	Secondary
S8	SPEECH	12 Jun 1987	USA / West	26 years on, the Wall was still a public weapon in the Cold War argument.	Primary
S9	GOVERNMENT DECREE	9 Nov 1989	East Germany	The Wall opened partly by accident — the decree was meant to start a day later.	Primary
S10	RESEARCH DATABASE	2017–19	Neutral / research	The human cost, established by evidence: at least 140 people killed at the Wall.	Secondary

A good line to finish your chart with: the strongest thing about this set of sources is that S1 and S2 are both East German — and they contradict each other. What a government said in public (S1, S3, S4) and what it said in private (S2, S5, S9) are two different histories. That contrast is the argument your chart can make.

Every one of these is a real, publicly accessible document. Type the address into a browser to see the original for yourself.

- S1** **Ulbricht press conference, 15 June 1961.** Transcript printed in *Neues Deutschland*, 16 June 1961.
germanhistorydocs.org/en/two-germanies-1961-1989/walter-ulbrichts-speech-on-the-berlin-question-june-15-1961
berlingeschichte.de/bms/bmsxt01/0106dokb.htm (German transcript of the exchange)
- S2** **Khrushchev–Ulbricht conversation, 1 August 1961.** Wilson Center Digital Archive, International History Declassified.
digitalarchive.wilsoncenter.org/document/notes-conversation-comrade-ns-khrushchev-comrade-w-ulbricht-1-august-1961
- S3** ***Neues Deutschland* front page, 14 August 1961.** German History in Documents and Images.
germanhistorydocs.org/de/zwei-deutsche-staaten-1961-1989/kommunistische-rechtfertigung-der-teilung-berlins-14-august-1961
nd-archiv.de/ausgabe/1961-08-14 (scanned original newspaper)
- S4** **SED pamphlet, 1961 — “In Praise of the Berlin Wall”.** German Propaganda Archive, Calvin University.
research.calvin.edu/german-propaganda-archive/schlugs13.htm
- S5** **Border brigade commander's report on Peter Fechter, 17 August 1962.** BArch, VA-07/16930. Chronik der Mauer.
chronik-der-mauer.de/todesopfer/171497/
chronik-der-mauer.de/en/victims/180502/fechter-peter (full account in English)
- S6** **Kennedy, Rudolph Wilde Platz, 26 June 1963.** US National Archives; transcript at the Miller Center; audio at the JFK Library.
millercenter.org/the-presidency/presidential-speeches/june-26-1963-ich-bin-ein-berliner-speech
jfklibrary.org/archives/other-resources/john-f-kennedy-speeches/berlin-w-germany-rudolph-wilde-platz-19630626
- S7** **East–West German migration statistics, 1949–1990.** German History in Documents and Images.
germanhistorydocs.org/en/two-germanies-1961-1989/east-west-german-immigration-statistics-1961-1990
germanhistorydocs.org/en/occupation-and-the-emergence-of-two-states-1945-1961/refugee-movement-1950-1963
- S8** **Reagan, Brandenburg Gate, 12 June 1987.** Ronald Reagan Presidential Library; also National Archives *Prologue*.
reaganlibrary.gov/archives/speech/remarks-east-west-relations-brandenburg-gate-west-berlin
archives.gov/publications/prologue/2007/summer/berlin.html
- S9** **GDR Council of Ministers travel decree, 9 November 1989 (“Schabowski's note”).** BStU, MfS, Arbeitsbereich Neiber Nr. 553. Chronik der Mauer.
chronik-der-mauer.de/en/material/180400/press-conference-with-guenter-schabowski-9-november-1989
- S10** **Victims at the Berlin Wall, 1961–1989.** Hertle & Nooke (eds.), ZZF Potsdam & Berlin Wall Foundation.
chronik-der-mauer.de/en/victims/
stiftung-berliner-mauer.de/en/topics/victims-berlin-wall

PHOTOGRAPHS

All eight photographs in [photo-sheet.html](#) come from **Wikimedia Commons**, which lists the photographer, date and copyright licence for each one. They are either **public domain** (the CIA photographs — works of the US federal government) or **CC BY-SA** (the German Federal Archive / Bundesarchiv photographs, which must be credited). The photographer and licence are printed under each photo on the sheet, so you can copy them straight onto your chart.

One photo you may have seen that is not included: the famous image of Peter Fechter dying in the border strip is held by the Berlin police historical collection and is still in copyright, so it cannot be reproduced here. You can view it on the Chronik der Mauer page listed under S5.